

LECTURE IX

ZARATHUSHTRA AND ISRAEL

From the rising of the sun even unto the going down of the same my name is great among the Gentiles; and in every place incense is offered unto my name, and a pure offering; for my name is great among the Gentiles, saith Yahweh of Hosts.¹

Malachi i. 11.

THE main purpose of this concluding Lecture is not that which will appear at first sight from its title. An active discussion has been going on for a generation as to the reality and extent of influences passing from one to the other of the two greatest religions of Western Asia. I naturally cannot decline all reference to this controversy, and hope to have something to say about it before I have done. But before suggesting any answer to the question whether Zarathushtra influenced Israel, or Israel Zarathushtra, I want to take a summary view of Parsism in the light of another religion, using the comparative method as a help to bring out the essential character of the religion which I am trying to interpret. The moral of the comparison may be reserved for the

¹ See E. Meyer, *Gesch. d. Alt.*, iii. 171, on the implication from the Jewish prophet's words that the everywhere worshipped God of heaven and Ruler of the world was in his mind identified with Yahweh.